

Cockatoo Body Signals

What their body and mood are telling you



Body condition, at a glance

Too thin

Keel bone very prominent, sharp ridge

Ideal

Keel felt with slight muscle coverage

Overweight

Keel hard to feel, rounded chest

Reading the signals

Happy looks like

- ♥ Relaxed feathers, soft chatter or singing
- ♥ Gentle head bobbing
- ♥ Beak grinding before sleep (a contented sound)
- ♥ A quick fluff-and-shake, then relaxing

Stressed looks like

- ♥ Feather plucking
- ♥ Pinned eyes with lunging or hissing
- ♥ Growling or hissing
- ♥ Staying puffed up for an extended time

A few enrichment ideas

- ♥ Foraging toys that hide treats tap into natural problem-solving instincts and prevent boredom
- ♥ Short daily training or step-up sessions build trust and give their sharp mind something to do
- ♥ Supervised out-of-cage time is essential — a cage-only life gets boring and stressful fast
- ♥ Rotate in one new toy at a time so novelty stays exciting without feeling overwhelming



Cockatoo Must-Knows



1

Diet: roughly 60% pellets, 30% vegetables, 10% fruit & nuts

2

Avocado is genuinely toxic to birds — it contains persin, which can damage their heart, unlike most pets

3

Never use non-stick (Teflon/PTFE) cookware near a bird — overheated fumes are fatal within minutes

4

Cockatoos are a serious commitment — smaller species like Goffin's commonly live around 40 years

5

Feather plucking can be a sign of stress, boredom, or unmet social needs

Bonus fun fact

Cockatoos are famously affectionate 'velcro birds' — they bond deeply with their people and need real daily interaction.

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The Cockatoo Parent Guide, Sitter Kit & Journal go way deeper — checklists, trackers, keepsakes & more, made just for your cockatoo.

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Cockatoo Emergency & Prep

What to watch for, and how to get ready



Call the vet if you see

- ♥ Tail bobbing with each breath, or open-mouth breathing
- ♥ Fluffed feathers for an extended time, or sitting low in the cage
- ♥ Discharge from the eyes or nares, or a drooping wing
- ♥ Not eating, or droppings looking very different than usual
- ♥ Feather plucking or self-mutilation — often a sign of stress, boredom, or unmet social needs

If something risky gets eaten

Call your vet or the ASPCA Animal Poison Control Center:
(888) 426-4435 — available 24/7

